Prime Readiness Map

Six gates stand between a capable shop and a defence buyer's order book. Which of them apply, and how far along the shop is, is what this map sets out — in the order they usually bite, so nothing gets done twice.
November 10, 2026.

Gate	What it is	Where you stand	What it takes	Who owns it
1. Registration	SAM.gov, UEI and CAGE code. Applies: If you sell, or want to sell, to a prime or the government	To be established at discovery: whether the registration is active, and the code it carries	Half a day of someone's time, free. The CAGE code takes about ten business days, and the registration renews every year — a lapse takes you off the books until it is fixed.	You do it; we keep the renewal on the calendar.
2. Cybersecurity	NIST SP 800-171, SPRS, and CMMC as the contract expresses it. Applies: When the work involves controlled data (CUI), or a prime asks	To be established at discovery: where controlled data lives, and what the shop already does about it	Planning bands for a full controlled-data scope, from our own effort table: shop IT 155–365 h; CGP + shop IT 60–140 h; owner 42–95 h; CGP 42–90 h. The scope decides the size of this: a shop handling only federal contract information is looking at fifteen requirements, a shop handling controlled data at a hundred and ten. Your IT provider does the configuration; the records and the evidence are the part with no natural home.	Your IT provider configures; we run the records, the evidence and the calendar.
3. Export control	ITAR registration with the State Department (DDTC). Applies: If you make anything on the munitions list, or handle its drawings	To be established at discovery: whether any part you make or quote is on the munitions list, and whether a registration is on file	Registration, renewed every year, even for a shop that never exports. The real work is naming who owns export compliance, with a backup, and controlling how drawings move. The State Department publishes the fee schedule.	You own the registration; we keep the record and the renewal date.
4. Quality	ISO 9001, AS9100, Nadcap for a special process, first-article records. Applies: If the buyer's supplier quality requirements say so — most aerospace and defence primes do	To be established at discovery: which certificates you hold, what each covers, and when it expires	A certificate cycle runs in months, not weeks, and buyers check the certificate's scope in the registrar's database. Special processes — heat treat, plating, welding, inspection — are accredited one at a time.	A registrar audits; your quality lead runs it; we keep it on the calendar.
5. Purchase order	The clauses that ride in with the order: CUI protection, counterfeit parts, traceability, and specialty metals. Applies: Every defence order, whether or not a prime says so out loud	To be established at discovery: which clauses your current orders carry, and whether melt origin is recorded on incoming material	Paperwork per order, plus a way to keep mill certificates tied to the lots they arrived with. Where the metal was melted has to be sorted before you quote, not after.	Your quality and purchasing people; we write the procedure.
6. Onboarding	The buyer's own supplier qualification. Applies: Before the first order: questionnaire, site visit, approved supplier list	To be established at discovery: which primes already have you on their supplier list	A capability and quality questionnaire, a day for a visit, and the buyer's own financial review. A loan approval is strong evidence, but it is not the buyer's test.	You, with the file prepared for you.

This is a map, not an assessment, and no certification or compliance is claimed here. Cybersecurity is the one gate where a third party has to sign in the end; the rest are record-keeping you can pass without an auditor. What each gate costs, and who says so, is on the next page.

What each gate costs

Every figure below carries who said it. **Official** means a rule, a fee the government sets, or a regulator's own page. **Vendor estimate** means what registrars and accreditation bodies quote in public — a band to price a conversation from, not a quote for this shop. **Planning estimate** is ours, and it is the one to check against a real provider's number before anyone commits.

Gate	What it costs	Class of figure	Where it comes from
1. Registration	Free. Nothing but attention, and about ten business days for the CAGE code to come back	official · 9 Nov 2026	SAM.gov registration guidance (SBA/GSA); CAGE assigned through SAM in about ten business days
2. Cybersecurity	Planning bands for a full controlled-data scope, by who does the work: shop IT 155–365 h; CGP + shop IT 60–140 h; owner 42–95 h; CGP 42–90 h. An assessment, if a contract calls for one, is a separate fee.	planning estimate	our own effort table, built from the NIST SP 800-171 catalogs
	It is also a doorway: the Joint Certification Program that lets a shop receive DLA technical data requires a NIST SP 800-171 assessment posted in SPRS, re-accomplished every three years, and it is phasing into a CMMC Level 2 certificate from a C3PAO between November 2025 and November 2028	official · 9 Nov 2026	DLA Joint Certification Program portal and JCP guide, July 2025
3. Export control	$3,000 a year at Tier 1 for a new registrant: $4,000 at Tier 2, $4,000 plus $1,100 per favourable determination at Tier 3. A qualifying Tier 1 registrant may petition for a $500 discount. The fee is annual whether or not the shop ever exports	official · 9 Nov 2026	DDTC registration fee tiers, ITAR 122.3(a), final rule 89 FR 99081 effective 9 January 2025
4. Quality	First year all in for a small shop with no quality system: about $15,000 to $50,000, split between implementation, consultancy and the audit. A shop that already holds ISO 9001 sits at the bottom of that	vendor estimate · 9 Nov 2026	2026 industry cost surveys for SMEs; small-org bands of $9,000 to $24,000 (under 25 staff, some QMS) and $30,000 to $80,000 (under 50 staff, implementation included)
	Months, not weeks, and nothing compresses it: 9 to 18 months for a machine shop with no quality system, 6 to 12 months from an existing ISO 9001	vendor estimate · 9 Nov 2026	2026 industry timelines; PRI recommends a six-month operating period before the audit
5. Purchase order	No published fee: the cost is per order. A written procedure, mill certificates tied to the lots they arrived with, and — the part that bites — sourcing settled before the quote, because where the metal was melted cannot be fixed mid-programme	industry estimate · 9 Nov 2026	DFARS specialty-metals and counterfeit-parts flow-downs (252.225-7009 and related); no published cost benchmark exists
6. Onboarding	Not priced anywhere, because the prime runs it: a capability and quality questionnaire, a site audit, its own financial review, and a place on its approved supplier list before a single order	no published figure · 9 Nov 2026	prime supplier-qualification processes; no published fee

None of this is a quote, and no gate is required until a contract or the prime's own supplier requirements say so: work out which apply first. Two of the six also carry the cheapest advice available — registering is free, and the federal government funds advisers for small businesses selling to it, so an owner should never pay for what is already free.

How the map gets filled in

Every row above marked "to be established at discovery" is answered by a short discovery, not by guesswork. That is the whole of the first piece of work: an hour with you, the documents you already have, and a walk through where controlled data and controlled drawings actually live.

What we need from you

- Which customers you sell to today, and which of them ask about cybersecurity or export control.
- Whether any part you make or quote is on the munitions list, or comes with a drawing marked as export-controlled.
- Any certificates you hold — quality, export, or veteran-owned — with their scope and expiry.
- The last three purchase orders from a defence customer, so the clauses on them can be read.
- Who does your IT, and whether they would take on a documented scope.

What comes back

- This map, with every row filled in and the ones that do not apply struck out.
- The order to take them in, and what each one costs in money and in hours.
- Who owns each — you, your IT provider, a specialist, or us.

Fee. Fixed, agreed in writing before the work starts, and it is the same whether or not a loan is ever made. Ask for the number and it will be in the engagement letter.

This page is what the map looks like before the discovery. Once it is filled in, it carries the shop's own position instead.